

MEXICAN BURROWING TOAD

The only member of the family Rhinophrynidae, the burrowing toad specializes in digging in soil and eating ants. It has a long, thin tongue that it sticks out of its narrow mouth.



6–8 cm
2¼–3¼ in

MEXICAN BURROWING TOAD

Rhinophrynus dorsalis

This unusually shaped toad spends most of its life burrowing underground, emerging only after rain to breed in temporary pools.

AMERICAN SPADEFOOT TOADS

This family consists of toads that live on dry land and stay inactive underground for long periods. The Scaphiopodidae emerge after rain to breed in temporary pools. These may evaporate quickly, so the tadpoles develop very rapidly.

5.5–9 cm
2¼–3½ in

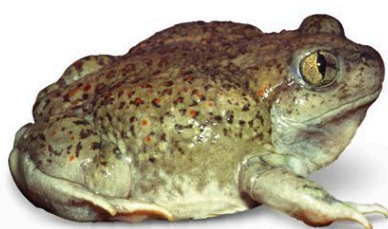


mottled greenish brown skin

PLAINS SPADEFOOT

Spea bombifrons

Found in arid plains of N. America and Mexico, this frog burrows by day. It gathers to breed in large numbers after heavy rain.



4–6 cm
1½–2¼ in

COUCH'S SPADEFOOT

Scaphiopus couchii

This N. American frog lives in arid areas, spending much of its time underground. It emerges at night to feed and, after heavy rain, to breed.

STRABOMANTIDAE

Many small frogs native to South America and the Caribbean make up this family. They are all direct developers: there is no tadpole stage and the egg hatches straight into a miniature adult.



LIMON ROBBER FROG

Pristimantis cerasinus

Hiding in leaf litter by day, but arboreal by night, this small frog is found in humid lowland forests of C. America.

1.5–3.5 cm
½–1½ in

2–4 cm
¾–1½ in

CHIRIQUI ROBBER FROG

Pristimantis cruentus

This small, terrestrial frog, found in C. and S. America, lays its eggs in crevices on tree trunks.

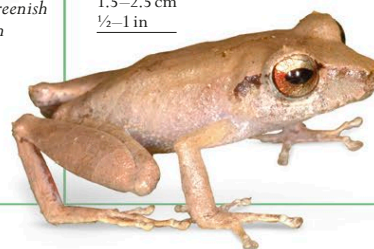


1.5–2.5 cm
½–1 in

PYGMY RAIN FROG

Pristimantis ridens

Found in the forests of C. and S. America, this tiny nocturnal frog thrives in gardens and lays its eggs in leaf litter.



CAECILIANS

Caecilians are long-bodied, limbless amphibians with little or no tail. Ring-shaped folds (annuli) in the skin give them a segmented appearance.

All caecilians live in the tropics. They vary in length from 12 cm (4¾ in) to 1.6 m (5¼ ft). Most live underground, burrowing in soft soil, using their pointed, bony head as a shovel. They emerge at night, especially after rain, to feed on earthworms,

termites, and other insects. Others live in water and resemble eels, rarely moving onto the land. These have a fin on the tail. With only rudimentary eyes, all rely on smell to find food and mates. A pair of retractable tentacles between the eyes and the nostrils transmit chemical signals to the nose.

In all caecilians, the eggs are fertilized internally. Some species lay eggs, but in others the eggs are retained inside the female's body. The young emerge either as gilled larvae or as small adults.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AMPHIBIA
ORDER	GYMNOPHIONA
FAMILIES	10
SPECIES	214



50 cm
20 in

PURPLE CAECILIAN

Gymnopsis multiplicata

This terrestrial caecilian from C. America lives in a wide range of habitats. The eggs hatch inside the female.

ICHTHYOPHIIDAE

Found in Asia, these caecilians lay eggs in soil near water. Females remain with their clutches, defending them until the larvae have made their way to open water.



33 cm
13 in

yellow stripe along body

KOH TAO CAECILIAN

Ichthyophis kohtaoensis

Found in a variety of habitats in S.E. Asia, this caecilian lays its eggs on land, but its larvae live in water.

DERMOPHIIDAE

These thick-set, cylindrical caecilians from Africa live beneath the surface and are mostly brown, grey, or dark purple in colour but may be yellow. Some species lack eyes. They give birth to live young.

CAECILIIDAE

Most species in this family are burrowers. Found in most tropical regions of the world, they vary greatly in length, some growing to over 1.5 m (5 ft). In some the eggs hatch into larvae; in others the larvae develop inside the female.

SANTA ROSA CAECILIAN

Caecilia attenuata

A rarely seen, greyish blue, burrowing species from the moist lowland forests of Amazonian Ecuador, this caecilian also occurs in degraded habitats including plantations and gardens.



37–91 cm
14½–36 in